

SkillUp

Lab: Affinity Charting

Estimated duration: 25 minutes

Learning Objectives

After completing this lab, you will be able to:

- 1. Identify and classify requirements as **Business, Functional, Non-Functional, or Transition**
- 2. Use the **MS Excel Affinity Charting Template** to group and organize requirements based on their natural relationships

Part I: Instructions

Step 1: Review the demo video

Watch this [short demonstration video](#) on how to use an **Affinity Chart** to organize unstructured requirements.

Note: If the video does not open, right-click and open the link in a new tab.

Step 2: Download the MS Excel template

Download the provided Excel file: [MS Excel Affinity Chart Template](#)

Note: If the file does not open, right-click and open the link in a new tab.

Step 3: Review the scenario

Read the interview notes below carefully. These represent a realistic stakeholder conversation for an **Inventory Management System Upgrade Project**.

Step 4: Identify requirements

Identify at least **three requirements** in each of the following categories:

- Business Requirements
- Functional Requirements
- Non-Functional Requirements
- Transition Requirements

Classify each stakeholder statement or implied need into one of these four categories.

Step 5: Create your Affinity Chart

1. Enter each requirement into your Excel template
2. Use the **Affinity Chart** tab to list and cluster related ideas
3. Use the **Category Summary** tab to summarize your grouped results

Step 6: Compare your solution

After completing your chart, review the sample requirements list and categorization recommendations provided in **Part II: Solution** for comparison.

Scenario: Inventory Management System Upgrade

Background

Fleet Ease Logistics operates a large warehouse that supports national retail distribution.

The company currently uses an outdated inventory system that lacks real-time visibility, automated alerts, and modern reporting.

A program has been launched to **upgrade the system** to improve accuracy, speed, and transparency across the supply chain.

You are a manager conducting an interview with:

- **Samantha Lee** – Warehouse Operations Manager
- **Ravi Patel** – IT Systems Lead
- **Maria Gomez** – Procurement Manager
- **David Chen** – Finance Analyst

Your job is to extract requirements and prepare them for categorization and affinity grouping.

Interview excerpts

Samantha Lee – Warehouse Operations Manager

- "Our biggest issue is delays in inventory updates. When shipments arrive, it can take hours before quantities show up in the system. We need real-time tracking of every pallet and SKU."*
- "Sometimes items are misplaced because the system doesn't flag duplicate bin entries. We'd like an automated alert if someone tries to store a product in the wrong location."*
- "I also want dashboards that show current stock levels, reorder points, and upcoming deliveries in one view. Right now, I have to pull three different reports to see that."*

Ravi Patel – IT Systems Lead

- "The new system must integrate smoothly with our existing ERP and procurement platforms. We can't afford downtime during the migration."*
- "We'll need to migrate about five years of inventory data. Accuracy is crucial, and we'll need time to test before going live."*
- "System speed is also important — updates should reflect within a few seconds, even when multiple users are logged in."*

Maria Gomez – Procurement Manager

- "I'd like automated reorder notifications when stock levels hit a threshold. That will save time and prevent shortages."*
- "Suppliers should be able to view and confirm orders through a portal instead of relying on emails. It would also be helpful if the system could flag delayed supplier shipments."*
- "If possible, I'd like to reduce manual entry errors. Maybe implement barcode scanning or mobile access in the warehouse."*

David Chen – Finance Analyst

- "Our CFO wants monthly reports that summarize inventory turnover, stock value, and aging items. Those reports must be exportable to Excel."*
- "We need to ensure accurate data validation and testing before we go live."*
- "It would be helpful if we had a short overlap period between the old and new systems, just in case of unforeseen issues."*

Part II: Solution — Potential categorization of identified requirements

#	Requirement	Category
1	Real-time tracking of pallets and SKUs	Business
2	Dashboard for stock levels, reorder points, and deliveries	Business
3	Monthly exportable reports on inventory turnover and stock value	Business
4	Reduced manual data entry errors through automation	Business
5	Automated alert for incorrect or duplicate bin entries	Functional
6	Automated reorder notifications for low stock levels	Functional
7	Supplier portal for order confirmations and shipment visibility	Functional
8	Barcode scanning or mobile entry for warehouse operations	Functional
9	Integration with existing ERP and procurement systems	Non-Functional
10	System updates reflect within seconds during high usage	Non-Functional
11	Role-based access control and data security compliance	Non-Functional
12	Data migration of five years of inventory records	Transition
13	Accurate data validation and testing before go-live	Transition
14	Overlap period (dual-run) between old and new systems	Transition

Conclusion

In this lab, you:

- Practiced identifying and classifying stakeholder requirements into four categories: Business, Functional, Non-Functional, and Transition.
 - Used an Affinity Chart to group related requirements and visualize patterns.
 - Reviewed a sample solution to understand how requirement types support different stages of a system upgrade project.
- By mastering requirement categorization, you enhance your ability to analyze stakeholder needs and contribute effectively to system design and documentation.

Author(s)

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